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Bazaar

Huawei P9

"Good" camera, better design

The Huawei P9 is all about the camera. Huawei took what it started with the Honor 6 Plus and almost perfected it. Leica has supplied its Summarit lenses for the two cameras on the P9. The company has used Sony's IMX286 sensors, one of which is an RGB sensor, while the other is a monochrome sensor.

Huawei's software combines data from both the sensors to produce the final image. The two sensors can also be used to create the famous bokeh effect, and you can of course use the monochrome sensor alone to take a black and white photo.

The monochrome sensor focuses only on black and white, thereby allowing more light. This, combined with the RGB sensor allows almost three times the light a regular smartphone camera would take. The sensors have a large 1.25 micron pixel size that allows more light data in images.

In practice, this results in some incredible photos. In its auto mode, the colours produced by the Huawei P9 may be considered a tad oversaturated, but that may be an effort at feeding general consumer preferences. You can, however, use the settings to reduce saturation to more natural levels. The same can also be said about the contrast, which some may consider too high, and can be tweaked. Colours on the Huawei P9, are retained in both brightly lit and low lit scenes.

However, the P9's low light photos, though, weren't as good as we expected. The camera does create good photos, but they aren't as bright as the Galaxy S7 Edge.

Further, for photos taken in sub-optimal light, the P9 does exhibit luminance noise. The phone is not aggressive at suppressing this noise, which may be good in the hands of a photographer. It also retain a lot of details.

While image quality is really good, all the software results in more processing time. Under low light, the P9 often pauses to take in more light, and the lack of OIS makes it prone to



shaky hands at this time. All of this makes the P9 a great camera phone, but not the best you can get. In fact, that's where the phone's design comes in. Its metallic body looks feel very premium and the two cameras also add to the visual appeal. The fingerprint sensor, power button and volume rocker are perfectly placed so that you never have to shift your grip.

Moving on, the display resolution on the P9 is only 1080p. This may be considered too low in a QHD world, but it's an efficient choice. The maximum brightness is 681 lux, and the colours are punchy. The lower resolution also amounts to higher than expected battery life.

The only issue we faced was with auto brightness. The Huawei P9 doesn't seem to adapt the brightness to the ambient light very well.

The biggest problem with the P9, though, is Huawei's EMUI. Huawei's UI looks childish, and it's also heavy. The only good thing about the UI is the battery manager, which allows you to drop the resolution to 720p if needed.

Speaking of battery, the 3000 mAh unit on the P9 doesn't last a full day, but it'll get by with one charge every night. You can expect about 4.5-5 hours of screen on time on regular usage.

Lastly, the Kirin 955 SoC on the P9 is 30% slower than the Snapdragon 820. You will only see slight frame skips on regular usage, while heavy games make it more evident. The processor can also heat up quite easily. Although we didn't get it over 40 degrees, it reaches that value very easily.

The Huawei P9 is a great smartphone and we loved using it. Yet, with a 40k price tag, it is hard to recommend. In this price, compromises are tough to forgive and the OnePlus 3 gives you much better value at a much lower price. On the other hand, the Samsung Galaxy S7 is more expensive, but a considerably better smartphone overall. The P9 is great, but not the best.

Prasad Banerjee

Price
₹39,999



Features 66
Design 93
Performance 74
Value 56

Specifications

Display: 5.2 inch FHD;
SoC: 2.5GHz Kirin 955 octa-core; **RAM:** 3GB;
Camera: 12 MP, dual-camera; **Operating System:** Android Marshmallow with EMUI; **Battery:** 3000 mAh; **Storage:** 32GB, Expandable to 256GB

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